

GTALES PARENT GUIDE 03 · BEING BULLIED

Shield Up, Little One

Clear science and simple daily steps to help your child speak up, find friends, and get grown-ups to act.

Shield up = strong voice · Shield down = hiding

The guide in 60 seconds

1. It is never your child's fault. Bullies pick children who seem to stand alone, not children who did something wrong.
2. The hidden cause is the audience. Other children watch almost every time, and when one steps in, the bullying often stops.
3. Your job is to act with the school, and to help your child find a strong voice and one good friend.

First, take a breath

If your child is being teased, left out, or hit, it is not their fault, and it is not yours. Bullying is very common, and children cannot stop it alone. With a few skills and a grown-up who acts, it usually gets better.

PART 1

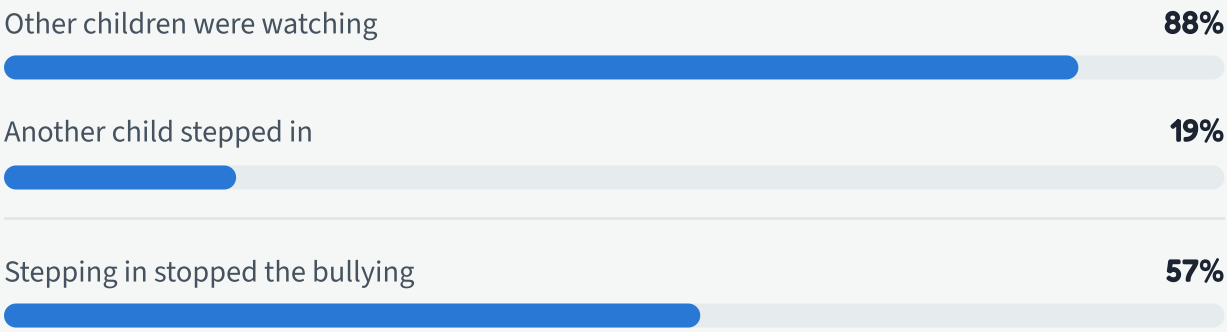
Understanding bullying

Not every fight is bullying. Friends argue, grab toys, and make up. Bullying has two parts: it happens again and again, and one child has more power, like being bigger, older, or more popular. It can be hitting, name-calling, or leaving a child out on purpose (StopBullying.gov). It is very common. Around the world, 32% of students say they were bullied in the last month, and in North Africa it is 42.7% (UNESCO, 2019).

Young children often feel bullying in their body first. They may get tummy aches, headaches, or bad sleep. A large review found bullied children are about twice as likely to have these body problems (Gini & Pozzoli, 2013). Many children also think, "It must be something about me." This self-blame makes them feel more sad and alone (Graham & Bellmore, 2007). Your calm words can change that story.

Other children almost always see bullying, but few step in, and when they do, it often stops

Video recordings of school playgrounds, 58 children in Grades 1 to 6 (about ages 6 to 12), Canada.



Source: Hawkins, Pepler & Craig, 2001, Social Development. The last bar is the share of step-ins (not of all episodes) that stopped the bullying.

More than half of bullied students never tell an adult at school

U.S. national survey of students ages 12 to 18 who were bullied, school year 2021–22. Younger children were not asked.



Source: NCES School Crime Supplement 2021–22, via StopBullying.gov

What it looks like at each age

Age 4–5

WHAT IS COMMON

Grabbing toys, pushing, and saying "You can't play" are common and often not bullying yet. Children this age are still learning to share and take turns.

WHEN TO LOOK CLOSER

The same child hurts or leaves out your child again and again. Your child says one name often, cries before school, or wets the bed or clings again.

Age 6–7

WHAT IS COMMON

Name-calling, teasing about looks, and leaving others out of games start to grow. Children notice who is popular.

WHEN TO LOOK CLOSER

Tummy aches on school mornings, lost or broken things, coming home very hungry, or saying "Nobody likes me."

Age 8

WHAT IS COMMON

Groups and "best friend" circles get stronger. Leaving out, spreading stories, and laughing in groups become more common.

WHEN TO LOOK CLOSER

Does not want to go to school, stops talking about friends, falls behind in school work, or seems very quiet and sad.

PART 2

Why it happens

THE SURPRISING PART

Bullying is often not about anger. It is a show for an audience, and the child who does it picks someone who seems to stand alone.

Researchers found that children who bully often want to look strong and popular. They choose targets who seem weaker and have fewer friends, so no one will stand up for them (Veenstra et al., 2010). On playgrounds, other children joined in or cheered in 81% of episodes (Craig & Pepler, 1997). So the fix is not to change your child. It is to change the group around your child: one friend, a helper child, and grown-ups who act.

Source: Veenstra et al., 2010

Three common myths

MANY PARENTS THINK

"Just hit them back."

WHAT RESEARCH SHOWS

In a study of 5- and 6-year-olds, boys who fought back kept being bullied. Boys who had a friend help were bullied less.

MANY PARENTS THINK

"Ignore it and it will stop."

WHAT RESEARCH SHOWS

Bullying is a show for an audience. Other children watched in 88% of playground episodes, and when one stepped in, it stopped 57% of the time.

MANY PARENTS THINK

"Telling is tattling."

WHAT RESEARCH SHOWS

More than half of bullied students never tell an adult at school. Teach the rule: if someone is hurt, scared, or it keeps happening, always tell.

Source: Kochenderfer & Ladd, 1997 · Hawkins et al., 2001 · StopBullying.gov

What's underneath

What you see on top is only a small part. Under the water, many hidden things keep bullying going.

WHAT YOU SEE

Tummy aches | Tears at school gate | "Nobody likes me" | Hiding at playtime

A show for others

The child who bullies often wants to look strong in front of others. Laughing or watching children give them the attention they want.

Source: Craig & Pepler, 1997

Picks lonely targets

Children who bully tend to choose children who seem weaker or less liked. This lowers the chance that someone will defend them.

Source: Veenstra et al., 2010

Few good friends

Children with few friends are more at risk. In one study, the risk did not show up for children who had many friends.

Source: Schwartz et al., 2000

Silent bystanders

Other children see most bullying but rarely step in. Many feel scared or do not know what to do.

Source: Hawkins et al., 2001

Self-blame

Bullied children often think, "It must be me." This belief makes them sadder and less likely to ask for help.

Source: Graham & Bellmore, 2007

Adults not told

More than half of bullied students never tell an adult at school. If grown-ups do not know, they cannot act.

Source: StopBullying.gov

What makes it worse

Telling your child "Just hit back" feels natural, but it does not work. In a study of 5- and 6-year-olds, boys who fought back kept being bullied, while boys who had a friend help were bullied less.

Source: Kochenderfer & Ladd, 1997

PART 3

In the moment: Listen, Lift, Learn, Link

When your child tells you about bullying, how you answer in the first minutes matters a lot. Stay calm so your child keeps telling you.



1

Listen first

Stop what you are doing and look at your child. Let them tell the whole story before you ask questions.

2

Lift the blame

Say clearly: "This is not your fault. Nobody should treat you like that." Thank them for telling you.

3

Learn the facts

Gently ask who, what, where, and how often. Write it down with dates so you can share it with the school.

4

Link with school

Contact the teacher soon and ask for a plan. Let the school talk to the other child, not you.

Children cannot stop bullying alone, so adults must step in, and the best results come when schools act as a whole team (StopBullying.gov; Gaffney et al., 2019).

What to say

SAY	INSTEAD OF
"Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing."	"Why didn't you tell me before?"
"This is not your fault."	"What did you do to make him angry?"
"I will talk to your teacher. We will fix this together."	"Just ignore them."
"You can stand tall and say, 'Stop. I don't like that.' Then walk to a grown-up."	"Just hit them back."
"Telling a grown-up to get help is not tattling."	"Don't be a tattletale."

After a hard day: the 4 Rs

Rest
Give a hug, a snack, and quiet time before you talk more.

Reassure
Remind your child that they are loved, it is not their fault, and you are on their side.

Report
Tell the teacher what happened, with the date, and ask what the school will do.

Recheck
Ask your child every few days, "How was playtime?" and follow up with the school if it continues.

PART 4

Every day, when everyone is calm

Small daily habits build a strong shield. They help your child feel safe, make friends, and keep telling you things.

Daily talk time

Ask simple questions at dinner or bedtime, like "Who did you play with today?" Listen without rushing to fix. Children who are used to talking tell more.

Grow one friendship

Invite one classmate to play at home or the park. Even one good friend makes a child less likely to be bullied.

Practice the strong voice

Play short games where your child stands tall and says, "Stop. I don't like that." A firm voice is a skill that grows with practice.

Name safe grown-ups

Help your child name three adults at school they can go to. Ask the teacher to let your child know they can always come.

Teach kind helping

Talk about how to help another child who is being teased. Children who stand by others build a kinder group for everyone.

Keep a short diary

Write down what your child tells you, with dates. This helps the school see the pattern and act.

This approach is proven

A review of 100 school program evaluations found anti-bullying programs cut bullying by about 19–20%. They cut being bullied by about 15–16%.

Source: Gaffney et al., 2019

PART 5

Seven activities that work

Each one takes a few minutes, uses things you already have, and practices one part of the Combo. Do them when everyone is calm.



Shield Up Pose

Ages 4–8 · 5 min · A mirror, the band (or a paper wristband)

1. Stand in front of the mirror together.
2. Show "shield down": head low, shoulders round, quiet voice.
3. Show "shield up": feet apart, back straight, eyes up.
4. Let your child switch between the two when you call "Up!" or "Down!".
5. Ask: "Which one feels stronger?"

Why it works: Children learn body language by copying. Standing tall is the first part of looking and feeling less like an easy target.

Combo Practice

Ages 4–8 · 5 min · None

1. Pretend something unkind just happened.
2. Do the Combo together: freeze and hug your tummy.
3. Take three slow breaths.
4. Say your Power Word.
5. Stand tall and say, "Stop. I don't like that."

Why it works: Calm breathing first helps the body settle, so the strong words come out clearly. Practicing when calm makes it easier when upset.

Strong Voice Game

Ages 4–8 · 5 min · A soft toy to play the teaser

1. Make the toy say a silly unkind thing, like "You smell like fish!"
2. Your child tries three voices: a mouse voice, a monster voice, and a strong calm voice.
3. Talk about which voice sounds most like "shield up".
4. Practice the strong calm voice: "Stop. I don't like that."
5. Then your child turns and walks away to you.

Why it works: Advice for children is to speak firmly and calmly, then walk away and tell an adult. Shouting or crying can give the bully the show they want.

Tell or Tattle

Ages 5–8 · 10 min · Paper, a pen, two bowls

1. Write or draw short cards, like "Sam hit me" or "Lina took a crayon once."
2. Label one bowl "Tell a grown-up" and one "I can handle it."
3. Your child sorts each card.
4. Teach the rule: if someone is hurt, scared, or it keeps happening, always tell.
5. Praise every good choice.

Why it works: More than half of bullied students never tell an adult. Learning that telling is not tattling helps adults find out and act.

Be a Buddy

Ages 4–8 · 10 min · Two or three toys or puppets

1. Act out one toy teasing another.
2. Your child plays a third toy who helps.
3. Practice helper words: "Come play with me" or "Stop, that's not kind."
4. The helper and the hurt toy walk away together to a grown-up.
5. Switch roles and play again.

Why it works: When another child stepped in on the playground, the bullying stopped in 57% of cases. Having a friend help was linked to less bullying in young boys.

Safe Hand

Ages 4–8 · 5 min · Paper, crayons

1. Trace your child's hand on paper.
2. On each finger, write or draw one grown-up they can tell, like a teacher or Teta.
3. Include at least two adults at school.
4. Hang it by the door.
5. Before school, ask: "Who is on your safe hand today?"

Why it works: Children are more likely to tell when they know exactly who to go to. This also reminds them they are not alone.

Friend Play Date

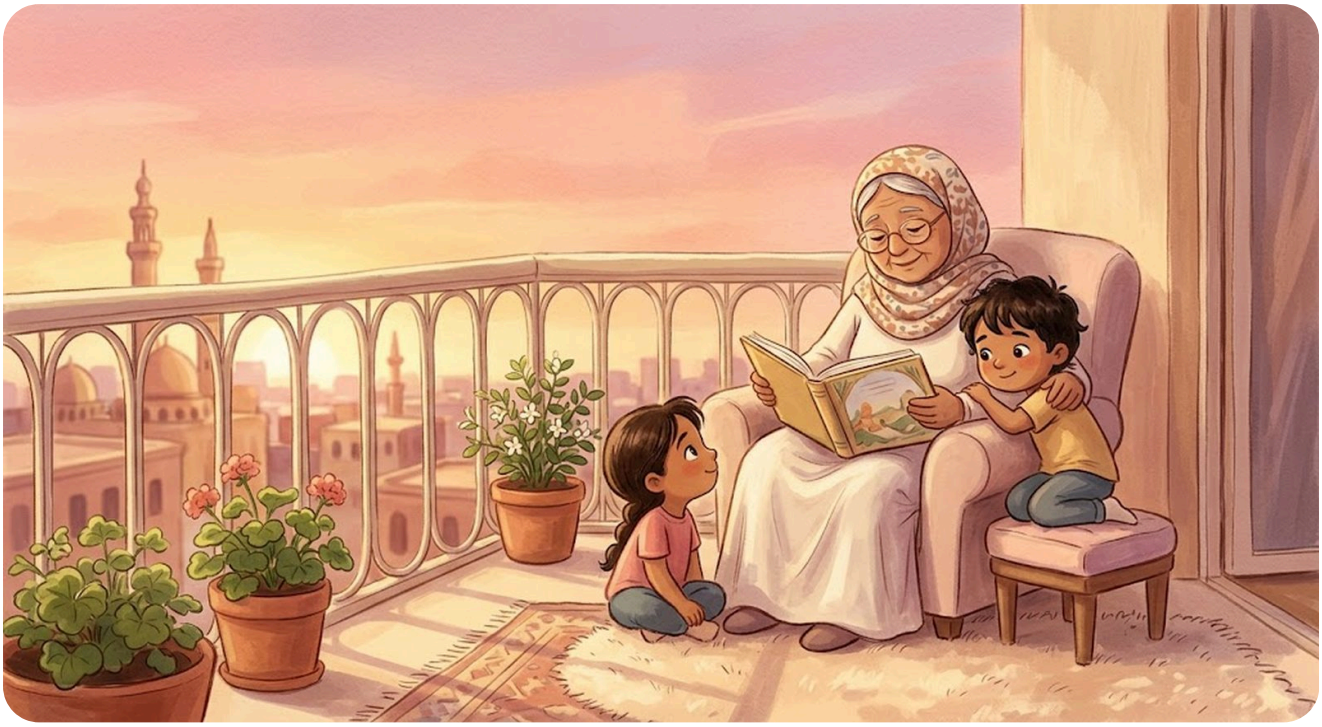
Ages 4–8 · 30 min · A simple game or a trip to the park

1. Ask your child which classmate they like.
2. Invite that child to play once a week.
3. Choose a game where they work as a team.
4. Afterward, ask: "What did you like about playing together?"
5. Tell the teacher this pair gets along well.

Why it works: Children with good friends are much less likely to keep being bullied. Friends act as protectors on the playground.

PART 6

Using your child's GTales story



Before

Show the cover and ask, "What do you think a shield does?" Tell your child the story is about a boy who learns to make his voice strong. Put on the band or a paper wristband together.

While reading

Pause when Snap the crab is unkind and ask, "Is the band showing shield up or shield down?" Do the Combo with the boy when he does it. When the boy tells Teta Turtle, say, "Telling is not tattling. That is shield up too." Let your child try the challenges and say "Stop. I don't like that." out loud.

After

Ask, "Whose fault was it when Snap was mean?" and help your child say, "Not mine." Talk about why Snap may feel lonely, and that grown-ups like Teta Turtle help both children. Ask, "Who is your Teta Turtle at school?"

Your 7-day plan

Day 1	Read the story together and play Shield Up Pose.
Day 2	Read again and practice the Combo three times.
Day 3	Play Strong Voice Game with a soft toy.
Day 4	Make the Safe Hand and hang it by the door.
Day 5	Play Tell or Tattle and praise every good choice.
Day 6	Play Be a Buddy and plan a play date with a classmate.
Day 7	Read the story once more and ask, "When did you use shield up this week?"

✂ CUT OUT AND KEEP ON THE FRIDGE

When someone is mean

1. Freeze and hug your tummy.
2. Three slow breaths.
3. Say your Power Word.
4. Stand tall: "Stop. I don't like that." Walk away. Tell a grown-up.

What grown-ups can say

- "Thank you for telling me."
- "This is not your fault."
- "I will talk to your teacher. We'll fix this together."

PART 7

When to get extra help

Most children get better with time, practice and calm support. Talk to a professional if you notice any of these:

- Your child is hurt, or you see injuries they cannot explain.
- The bullying continues after you have told the school.
- Your child refuses to go to school or cries every morning.
- Tummy aches, headaches, or bad sleep go on for weeks.
- Your child seems very sad, stops playing, or says "I'm bad" or "Nobody likes me" a lot.
- Your child hurts themselves or talks about not wanting to live.
- Your child starts hurting other children or animals.

If the school does not act, ask to meet the principal or school counselor and bring your written notes. If your child seems very sad or worried, see your pediatrician or a child psychologist; cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), a talking therapy that teaches coping skills, is a well-studied treatment for anxiety and depression in children.

Asking for help is a strong parenting move, not a failure.

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